Chapter 7.

QUAD: A GROUPING FORETOLD

When Common Good Requires Fresh Thinking

The importance of the Indo-Pacific as a theatre and the Quad as a diplomatic platform is increasingly being recognized. Some may be interested in their novelty; others may think of them as real global change that is underway. Understandably, they have been the subject of debate and, in some quarters, even of polemics. Both subjects predate the Covid pandemic but have been shaped by it. We intuitively know that it has taken considerable diplomatic energy and determination to realize them.

With its meetings raised to a summit level, the Quad is no longer a bureaucratic mechanism but, instead, a gathering key to national interests. As we contemplate how this came about so rapidly, the more perceptive would appreciate that these were developments just waiting to happen. Indeed, this is a tale of a grouping foretold. But even for that to happen, it required global trends to intersect with strategic clarity and bold leadership. A steady course was equally important as the understandable resistance to a break from the past also unfolded.

After Lord Rama was sent into a forest exile on the eve of his coronation, he thereafter met up with his half-brother Bharata, in whose favour that decision was made. Their meeting (known famously as Bharata Milap) is, of course, a favourite subject for artistic and cultural depiction in the ages since. The hunter-king Guha, on whose lands this encounter takes place, observed the gathering of the four brothers (as the twins Lakshmana and Shatrugana were also there). He marvelled that despite each having their own interests and perspectives, they displayed very visible affection towards each other. It was not that there were no differences or tensions amongst them. Lakshmana, in particular, was deeply aggrieved at the invoking of the boons by Bharata's mother Kaikeyi and that continued to influence his outlook.